



**FRESHMAN
ACADEMY**

INTERNAL GUIDE · FOR ALL EMPLOYEES

Goal Setting Guidelines

How to write effective, accurate, and actionable goals? The guide includes examples from Freshman Academy.

VERSION

1.1

May 2026

APPROVED BY

Valera Arakelyan

CEO, Freshman Academy

OWNER

Safina Teshabayeva

COO



1 Why Goals Matter

At Freshman, every department leader fills in weekly goals by **Sunday midnight**, and the monthly plan by the **last working day of the given month**.

Vague goals introduce confusion and inefficiency. Conversely, specific goals lead to accountability and momentum.

The test: Give your goal to someone from a different department. Can they tell you on Sunday whether it was achieved or not — without asking you any questions? If not, rewrite it. Simple as that.

2 The SMART Checklist

There's a checklist called SMART. Sounds corporate — isn't. It's just five questions to run your goal through before you submit:

S Specific What exactly? Could a stranger understand it?	M Measurable How much? How many? If there's no number, it's not measurable.	A Achievable Can it actually be done with what you have right now?	R Relevant Does it actually matter for the business?	T Time-bound A real date and time. "End of week" doesn't count.
--	---	--	--	---

3 The Goal Formula

When you're staring at a blank goal field and don't know where to start, this formula works every time:

[Action verb] + [what exactly] + [number / target] + [by when — specific date and time]

Monthly goal example: "Launch two admissions programs with 100% occupancy by May 31."

Weekly goal example: "Interview 15 students and close 8 admissions cases by Sunday, May 18 at midnight."

Deadline format: Always write the full date and time. "By Friday May 10 at 5:00 PM" — not "end of week," not "soon," not "ASAP." If you write "ASAP" as a deadline, it means there is no deadline.

No jargon. Write it so everyone understands

We have people here from very different backgrounds. If someone from the Academic team reads a Marketing goal and doesn't understand it — that's a problem with the goal, not the reader. Same goes in reverse. Write as if you're explaining it to a new hire on their first day.

These words are banned in goals and tasks: SOP · CPL · ROI · CTR · MOU · pipeline · funnel · B2B · top-of-funnel · KPI

Write the real thing instead. "cost per new student inquiry" not CPL. "our standard intake process" not SOP. "how many people clicked our ad" not CTR. There is a plain English version for everything — use it.

4 Goals and Tasks Are Not the Same Thing

Goals are results you commit to. If a goal doesn't get done by Sunday — you explain why at the Monday meeting. They go in the goals section. That's the list leadership reads first.

Tasks are the specific actions that get you to the goal. Each one should take **30 to 60 minutes**. If it takes three hours, it's not a task — break it into parts. Tasks go in the tasks section. Do not put tasks in the goals section.

GOAL (WEEKLY)

"Interview 15 students and close 8 admissions cases by Sunday midnight"

✓ Outcome. Measurable. Specific deadline. Matters to the business.

GOAL (MONTHLY)

"Launch two admissions programs with 100% occupancy by May 31"

✓ Clear outcome. Number (2 programs, 100%). Hard deadline.

Tasks under these goals would look like:

- Call 30 waitlisted candidates from April — by Tuesday 6 PM
- Send enrollment links to all accepted students — by Wednesday noon
- Update the group status in the system — by Thursday 5 PM

Each task is a **single action**, takes **30–60 minutes**, and has a **specific owner and deadline**.

Tasks are not goals: "Call some candidates" is a task — not a goal. "Interview 15 students" is a goal. Do not put tasks in the goals section of your plan.

5 Examples by Department · Vague vs Specific

For each department — what we usually see on the left, and what we actually need on the right.

Department	✗ Vague (wrong)	✓ Specific (right)
Admissions Program	<i>"Get more students enrolled"</i>	<i>"Interview 15 students, close 8 admissions cases by Sunday midnight"</i>
SAT	<i>"Prepare students for the test"</i>	<i>"Enroll 12 students, run 3 practice tests, reach average score of 1180 by May 25"</i>
AP Courses	<i>"Improve student results"</i>	

Department	❌ Vague (wrong)	✅ Specific (right)
		"Enroll 10 students, maintain 88% attendance, average practice score 4 or above by May 31"
Advanced English	"Develop the English program"	→ "Enroll 15 students across 2 levels, complete 8 lessons per group, assess all students by May 31"
Full Support	"Help students apply to universities"	→ "Submit applications for 8 students to 3 universities each; secure 2 conditional offers by May 31"
Master's Program	"Work on master's applications"	→ "Write and submit personal statements and documents for 5 students to 2 programs each by May 31"
Research Institute	"Do research and meet partners"	→ "Complete 2 research reports, hold 3 partner meetings, publish 1 update by May 31"
Imkon Project	"Find jobs for students"	→ "Place 5 students in internships, sign 1 new partner agreement, generate \$2,000 in revenue by May 31"
B2B Projects	"Run sessions at Thompson"	→ "Conduct 12 sessions with 20 students, maintain 90% satisfaction, submit monthly report by May 31"
Marketing	"Grow our social media"	→ "Generate 80 new student inquiries through Instagram and Telegram, grow page followers by 600 by May 31"
Sales	"Close deals and make sales"	→ "Contact 60 leads, close 12 deals, generate \$8,000 in revenue by May 31"

6 Useful Verbs to Start With

If you're stuck, start here. Pick a verb, add the object, add a number, add a date:

Sales & Revenue

Close · Sign · Generate · Convert · Secure · Negotiate · Acquire · Upsell · Win

Academic & Programs

Enroll · Conduct · Assess · Score · Deliver · Complete · Certify · Graduate · Launch

Marketing

Publish · Grow · Attract · Run · Post · Reach · Promote · Broadcast · Distribute

Operations

Build · Create · Implement · Reduce · Submit · Process · Update · Automate · Cut

 Partnerships

Partner · Place · Meet · Present · Onboard · Connect ·
Renew · Expand · Establish

 Research & Reporting

Analyse · Measure · Survey · Document · Track · Report ·
Review · Compile · Present

Banned words — replace every one:

improve · work on · develop · enhance · try to · focus on · look into · help with · deal with · manage · oversee · support ·
coordinate · handle · ensure

These words describe activities, not results. They give you an escape route when someone asks "did you do it?"
Replace every single one with a concrete verb, a number, and a date.

7 Rules We Follow

1**No number, no goal**

No number means no accountability. "Increase awareness" could mean anything. "Reach 500 new student inquiries" is something we can look at on Monday.

2**Outcome, not activity**

"Run 3 info sessions" is a task. "Enroll 10 students through 3 info sessions" is a goal. Write the result.

3**One owner per goal**

"We will close 10 deals" — who exactly is "we"? Name one person. That person is responsible. Everyone else supports.

4**Write the actual date**

"By Friday May 10 at 5:00 PM" — not "end of week," not "ASAP," not "this month."

5**Five goals a week, no more**

If you have 12 priorities, you have zero priorities. Pick the 5 that matter most. Put everything else in tasks or next week.

6**Tasks should be quick**

A task is something you can sit down and finish before lunch. If it keeps getting pushed because it feels too big — it's not a task, it needs to be broken down.

7**If it doesn't connect to results, cut it**

Before you submit — ask yourself: if this goal goes unfinished, does the business notice? If the answer is no, it probably doesn't belong in the plan.

8**Be honest about % done**

60% complete is honest and useful. 100% on everything, every week, is not realistic — and we all know it. Report what actually happened.

8 Mistakes We See and How to Fix Them

Mistake	Example of the mistake	How to fix it
Describing your job, not your goal	<i>"Manage the Admissions Program process"</i>	Add result: "Enroll 8 students into the June group by May 31"
No number	<i>"Increase student satisfaction"</i>	"Achieve satisfaction score of 4.5 out of 5 in the May survey"
No deadline	<i>"Launch new curriculum"</i>	"Launch new AP curriculum by Friday May 20 at 5 PM"
Using jargon nobody understands	<i>"Optimise CPL in top-of-funnel"</i>	"Reduce the cost of each new student inquiry to under \$4 by May 31"
Putting tasks inside goals	<i>"Call candidates this week"</i>	Move to tasks. Goals = outcomes. Tasks = actions.
Reporting 100% on everything	<i>% Done: 100%, 100%, 100%</i>	Be honest. Partial completion is useful data for everyone.

Before submitting your plan — check each goal:

- ☐ Does it contain at least one number?
- ☐ Does it have a specific date and time (not "soon" or "this week")?
- ☐ Is there one named owner?
- ☐ Is it an outcome, not an activity or job description?
- ☐ Can someone outside the department evaluate it on deadline day?
- ☐ Is it written in plain language — no abbreviations or jargon?
- ☐ Does it connect to enrollment, revenue, or student outcomes?

If you answer no to any of these — do not submit yet. Fix the goal first. It takes two minutes and saves everyone confusion for the rest of the week.

Reference · Keep This Handy

Print this · pin it somewhere visible · use it every Sunday



[Action verb] + [what exactly] + [number] + [date and time]

✓ STRONG VERBS

- **Sales:** Close · Sign · Generate · Convert · Secure
- **Academic:** Enroll · Conduct · Assess · Complete · Launch
- **Marketing:** Publish · Grow · Attract · Run · Reach
- **Ops:** Build · Implement · Submit · Reduce · Cut
- **Partnerships:** Place · Onboard · Connect · Establish

📋 SMART

- **S** — Specific: clear what needs to be done
- **M** — Measurable: has a number
- **A** — Achievable: realistic for the timeframe
- **R** — Relevant: tied to business outcome
- **T** — Time-bound: specific date and time

✗ BANNED WORDS

- improve · work on · develop · enhance
- try to · focus on · look into · help with
- manage · oversee · coordinate · handle
- SOP · CPL · ROI · CTR · MOU (write in full)

⚡ 8 RULES (SHORT)

- 1 · Must have a number
- 2 · Outcome, not activity
- 3 · One owner per goal
- 4 · Real date and time deadline
- 5 · Max 5 goals per week
- 6 · Tasks = 30–60 min each
- 7 · Connect to business results
- 8 · Report % honestly

✓ BEFORE YOU SUBMIT — CHECK EACH GOAL:

- ☐ Contains at least one number
- ☐ Has a specific date and time
- ☐ Has one named owner
- ☐ Describes an outcome, not an activity
- ☐ Written in plain language — no jargon or abbreviations
- ☐ Someone outside the team can evaluate it on deadline day

APPROVED BY · CEO

Valera Arakelyan

Freshman Academy

PREPARED BY · COO

Safina Teshabayeva

Freshman Academy